

Cultural Sensitivity

What is culture?

- “. . . people with common origins, customs and styles of living, who share a sense of identity and language. Their common experiences shape their values, goals, expectations, beliefs, perceptions and behavior”
- Culture is “all those things that people have learned to do, believe, value, and enjoy in their history. . . the ideals, beliefs, skills, tools, customs, and institutions into which each member of society is born”.
- **There is your own culture and the culture of others.**

Self-Cultural Awareness

Why do we need to be critically cognizant of our own culture?

- To understand the reasons for our actions and reactions; based upon the social constructions of our culture
 - These social constructions can differ from culture to culture.
- To realize that the socially acceptable/ unacceptable social constructions within a culture are 'natural and common sense' to the people in that culture because they are continuously a part of their way of life; learned from an early age

Self-Cultural Awareness Cont...

Why do we need to be critically cognizant of our own culture?

- To ensure we do not take the 'natural, common sense' practices for granted and become or remain ethnocentric.
 - “. . . [people have a] tendency to regard one's own cultural group as the center of everything and the standard to which all others are compared

- To facilitate increased acceptance of other cultures by the realization that there are no right or wrong cultural beliefs (
- Increased willingness to learn cross culturally.
- Provides an opportunity to suppress unfounded preconceived notions, stereotypes and prejudices through this education.

Cross-Cultural Awareness

So, why do we need to be critically cognizant of other people's culture?

- To facilitate awareness and understanding of other people's actions and reactions (
 - Prevents misunderstandings due to a lack of awareness.
- To create a climate that is conducive to maximum working output; providing their culture is included in the workplace instruction (
 - employees not feeling isolated as 'outsiders'

How can we facilitate self-cultural and cross-cultural awareness?

- Culture shock activity
 - Can be “ a powerful learning tool”
- Culturally Responsive Workplace
 - Inclusion of employees cultural references in all aspects of professional life

National vs corporate culture

•National culture

- Religion Religion plays the role of a foundation stone in every aspect of human life .
- Social organization Social organization is another key element of nation cultural system. Different cultures have different social systems or system to organize the society around family systems, neighborhood, ethnic groupings, and tribal systems for instances
- Language
- Time concept
- Power distance
- Collectivists-individualistic
- Masculinity-femininity
- Uncertainty avoidance

•**Corporate management culture**

- General management styles
- decision making
- staffing
- controlling
- time management
- employee motivation
- role of religion in the workplace

Pakistani culture

- **Basic Etiquette**

- People tend to offer regular praise about others' clothes, hair or personal items.
- Wear clothes appropriate to specific occasions. Forgetting to do so is considered disrespectful.
- It is best to always dress modestly in a way that doesn't over-accentuate one's figure.
- Laughing loudly in public is considered rude.
- Stand to greet a person when they enter a room.
- It is considered rude to sit with one's legs outstretched.

Visiting

- Hospitality is a strong aspect of Pakistani culture. It is not uncommon to be invited to a Pakistani's home without much prior acquaintance
- If visiting a military family's house, arrival should be prompt. More generally, however, Pakistanis are not particularly strict with time. Arriving to an event substantially later than the start time is acceptable, though this depends upon the context of the event.
- With new acquaintances, it is not expected to offer to bring something for a meal. Hosts take pride in preparing everything themselves and may be taken aback by such a question.

- It is polite to bring a small gift, such as chocolate, sweets or flowers to express gratitude for the invitation.
- Offer to remove your shoes at the entrance.
- It is important to praise the host's home. If it is a simple home, acknowledge their décor and contents.
- When visiting a home with children, make an effort to engage with them no matter how young they are. Not doing so displays disinterest in your host and is considered arrogant behaviour.
- In more intimate or smaller settings, the entire family will sit together with guests in the living room.
- Avoid discussing politics when initially invited into a household, unless initiated by the host.

Eating

- It's polite to graciously accept tea and refreshments served in social situations.
- People wait for elders to sit down and begin before eating.
- Pakistanis will often use their hands to eat rather than cutlery. However, it is considered bad etiquette to pass, serve or spoon food to one's mouth with the left hand. It should be used to hold the plate or assist the right hand in serving food.
- Pakistanis often offer their guests additional helpings of food. It is acceptable to refuse; however, expect the host to insist. It can be easier and also more polite to graciously accept.
- If offered food you don't like or perhaps a 'hookah', you may place your hand on your heart and bow your head to decline the offer.

Gift Giving

- Gifts should be offered and received with two hands or
- the right hand alone.
- If it is a Muslim household, do not bring alcohol, and ensure
that all edible products are prepared to standards.

- In more conservative settings, it is not appropriate for men to offer gifts to women. Therefore, they must convey that the gift is being offered on behalf of a female family member. For example, “my wife gave me this for you”